



Pitch Creation and Competition Timeline

By Nikolay Zekert, Andrey Mukhin

Timur Zafesov, Donald Ong

A strong commodity pitch explains why the market is wrong and how to trade it

A forecast becomes investable only when physical evidence connects mispricing to a catalyst, expression and invalidation

01 DISLOCATION

What is mispriced?

A price, basis, spread, processing margin or linked equity diverges from the physical market

LOOK FOR price ≠ fundamentals

02 DIFFERENTIATED THESIS

What do we see differently?

Name the assumption the market underestimates, overlooks or prices incorrectly

NOT ENOUGH "Demand will rise."

03 CATALYST

Why reprice now?

Specify the mechanism and timeframe that forces the market to notice

INVENTORY • OUTAGE • STARTUP • POLICY • WEATHER

04 TRADE EXPRESSION

Where is the cleanest payoff?

Choose the instrument that best isolates the view and offers asymmetric reward

FUTURES • SPREADS • OPTIONS • RELATIVE VALUE • EQUITY

05 RISK / INVALIDATION

What proves us wrong?

Define the critical assumption, observable failure signal and exit response

A THESIS MUST BE FALSIFIABLE

BOTTOM LINE

GOOD PITCH = MISPRICING + EXPLANATION + CATALYST + TRADE + RISK

The right topic survives five filters to become a trade

Start broad, then narrow until the view is specific, catalytic and executable

01 CHOOSE A MARKET

Energy · Metals · Agriculture · Softs · Freight

02 SPOT AN ANOMALY

Inventories · spreads · constraints · flows · bottlenecks

03 EXPLAIN THE MISPRICING

“Why is the current price wrong?”

04 REQUIRE A CATALYST

What changes before the trade horizon?

05 MAKE IT TRADEABLE

Instrument · entry · target · horizon · downside · exit

No clear answer at any stage? Stop, the topic is not ready

THEME ≠ TRADE

A broad narrative becomes a pitch only when it points to a priced instrument

WEAK THEME

“AI will lift copper demand”

TRADEABLE TOPIC

A supply constraint is missing from a specific copper spread

WEAK THEME

“Oil rises on geopolitics”

TRADEABLE TOPIC

A grade/location disruption creates a relative-value gap

Research is a chain from physical flow to price target

Each step should add evidence instead of complexity for its own sake

01 PHYSICAL MARKET	02 BALANCE	03 PRICE STRUCTURE	04 CATALYST	05 EXPECTATIONS	06 MODEL
Map the chain	Quantify the shift	Read beyond spot	Build the calendar	Test the edge	Derive the target
Find the constrained link	Track inventories vs. history	Curve · spreads · basis · margins	Know when the thesis can surface	New information or priced in?	Scenarios · sensitivity · regression

THE CORE BALANCE

**Supply + Imports - Demand - Exports
= Δ Inventories**

Compare the change with history and normal seasonality.

THE MARKET SIGNAL

**Curve · calendar spreads ·
geographic basis · processing
margins**

Structure shows whether physical tightness is reaching price.

THE DECISION QUESTION

**Is this information new or already
reflected in the price?**

MODEL OUTPUT → PRICE TARGET

SOURCE HIERARCHY

PRIMARY DATA → INDUSTRY DATA → COMPANY INFO → NEWS / COMMENTARY

A strong pitch moves from recommendation to execution

The story should answer seven questions in the order the audience needs them

01 THESIS / TRADE

What are we trading?

Direction · entry · target · horizon

02 MARKET SETUP

Where is the imbalance?

One or two charts, not ten

03 WHY THE MARKET IS WRONG

What is pricing missing?

The intellectual center

04 CATALYST / WHY NOW

What closes the gap?

Mechanism + timing

05 VALUATION / RETURN

What should it be worth?

Method behind the target

06 TRADE CONSTRUCTION

Why this instrument?

Months · structure · sizing

07 RISKS & INVALIDATION

What ends the trade?

Adverse case + exit signal

THE 30-SECOND TEST

Trade + direction + entry + target + horizon

BUILD THE STORY

SETUP → EDGE → CATALYST → PAYOFF

Every section should make the trade easier to execute

CLOSE WITH TWO DIFFERENT QUESTIONS

RISK hurts the trade
INVALIDATION makes the thesis wrong

Define the data that triggers a hedge, resize or exit

BOTTOM LINE

The pitch is not the research archive, but the shortest defensible path to an executable trade

UCC Pitches

Judges test whether the argument holds together

Use the four lenses below to organize verified judge feedback and prepare for Q&A

01 MARKET UNDERSTANDING

Can the team explain the physical market—not merely repeat reports?

Physical chain · constraints · units

2026 COMMENT _____

02 THESIS QUALITY

Is there a genuine mispricing and a differentiated reason for it?

Mispricing · insight · evidence

2026 COMMENT _____

03 TRADE CONSTRUCTION

Does the instrument isolate the thesis with coherent entry, target and risk?

Expression · horizon · sizing

2026 COMMENT _____

04 DEFENSE UNDER Q&A

Can the team defend assumptions, sensitivities and weaknesses without the deck?

Assumptions · sensitivities · limits

2026 COMMENT _____

THE COHERENCE TEST **SUPPLY / DEMAND → CATALYST → TRADE STRUCTURE → RISK**

A correct directional call is not enough; every link must support the next.

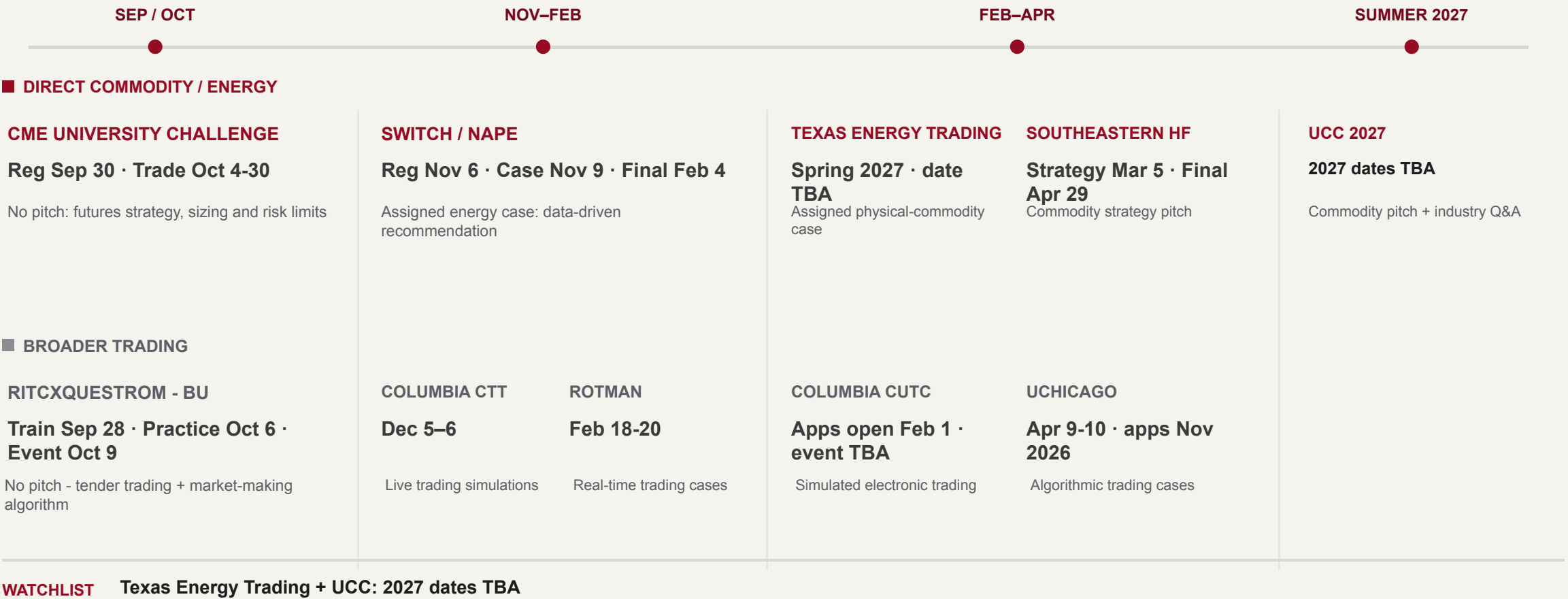
EVERY EXHIBIT MUST ANSWER

“Why is the market wrong?”

“Why will our trade make money?”

One calendar, two distinct preparation tracks

Commodity competitions require cases or pitches; broader events test execution and algorithms.



DIRECT COMMODITY / ENERGY

SEP / OCT	NOV–FEB	FEB–APR	SUMMER 2027
CME UNIVERSITY CHALLENGE Reg Sep 30 · Trade Oct 4-30 No pitch: futures strategy, sizing and risk limits	SWITCH / NAPE Reg Nov 6 · Case Nov 9 · Final Feb 4 Assigned energy case: data-driven recommendation	TEXAS ENERGY TRADING Spring 2027 · date TBA Assigned physical-commodity case	SOUTHEASTERN HF Strategy Mar 5 · Final Apr 29 Commodity strategy pitch
			UCC 2027 2027 dates TBA Commodity pitch + industry Q&A

BROADER TRADING

SEP / OCT	NOV–FEB	FEB–APR	SUMMER 2027
RITCXQUESTROM - BU Train Sep 28 · Practice Oct 6 · Event Oct 9 No pitch - tender trading + market-making algorithm	COLUMBIA CTT Dec 5–6 Live trading simulations	ROTMAN Feb 18-20 Real-time trading cases	COLUMBIA CUTC Apps open Feb 1 · event TBA Simulated electronic trading
			UCHICAGO Apr 9-10 · apps Nov 2026 Algorithmic trading cases

WATCHLIST Texas Energy Trading + UCC: 2027 dates TBA

Source: user-provided CTC planning brief · 2027 dates marked TBA where unpublished

Competition readiness is a repeatable operating system

Select early, divide the work, pressure-test the thesis, then rehearse the defense.

01 COMPETITION → 02 TEAM → 03 RESEARCH / CASE → 04 TRADE → 05 INTERNAL REVIEW → 06 MOCK Q&A → 07 SUBMISSION

1 SELECT THE OPPORTUNITY

Track deadlines · eligibility · team size · advisor · travel

2 BUILD THE TEAM

Combine fundamental research, quantitative skill and presentation / Q&A strength.

PITCH PATH

Screen topic → one-page thesis → deep research → model → trade → deck

CASE / TRADING PATH

Learn rules → assign roles → practice scenarios → set risk limits → review performance

THE TWO QUALITY GATES

INTERNAL IC

Mispriced? · Why now? · Priced in? · Trade? · What breaks it?

MOCK Q&A

Bring in outsiders. Attack assumptions for 10–15 minutes—without relying on the deck.

FIND THE DISLOCATION → UNDERSTAND THE PHYSICAL MARKET → IDENTIFY THE CATALYST → EXPRESS THE TRADE → KNOW WHAT MAKES YOU WRONG